

## Life-saving pyjamas

**S**udden infant death syndrome (SIDS) is the single biggest killer of infants under one year in developed countries. Belgian researchers are hoping that a baby suit or pyjamas based on space technology may help save the lives of the little ones.

The prototype pyjamas include five sensors built into the fabric that will monitor the baby's breathing and heartbeat. The sensors are connected to a small



detection unit that triggers an alarm if it detects any abnormalities. Further, the sensors have no direct contact with the skin, thus minimising

any discomfort to the child.

Verhaert ([www.verhaert.com](http://www.verhaert.com)), a European systems development group which developed the underlying technology, says that extensive trials in Portugal and Germany have yielded encouraging results and the medical community's feedback has been positive. These suits are slated to hit the market in 18 months.

## Internet semantics

Tim Berners-Lee, the inventor of the World Wide Web, is a man on a mission—to make the Web smarter. He aims to weave a Semantic Web that links documents to each other and recognises the meaning of the information in those documents. Berners-Lee says that adding semantics to the Web changes it from being a publishing medium to a medium where diverse data can be interpreted and exchanged. How many times have you searched for a particular work and ended up with irrelevant search results? The Semantic Web will change all that with Semantic-enabled search agents collecting machine-readable data from diverse sources, processing it, and inferring new facts to give you what you want.

## Unconnectedness

If you plan to surf while flying Boeing, you'll have to wait. Connexion, a project by Boeing and its three partners (American Airlines, Delta Air Lines, and UAL's United Airlines), had plans to put high-speed Internet connection on Boeing planes. The plan has now been shelved. Boeing's partners pulled out of the project following severe losses as a result of the September 11 terrorist attacks. Plans were to provide Internet services via satellite.

## Zaurus the Linux

The Japanese electronics maker, Sharp, has recently unveiled a retail version of its Linux-based PDA, Zaurus, which it plans to make available in the US early next year. The commercial version, renamed the Zaurus SL-5500, features a small, retractable keyboard and two



expansion slots for Compact Flash and Secure Digital cards. Sharp currently sells the Zaurus SL-5000D to developers for \$399 (approximately Rs 19,152) from its Web site. The company is looking to drum up support among developers worldwide for developing applications on the Zaurus.

## metrics

**70%**  
**3 billion**

of all Internet users started surfing the Web in 1998 (Gartner)

Web documents can be accessed by Google any minute

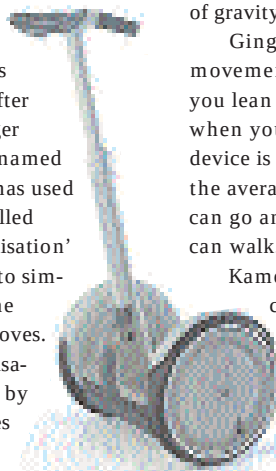
## tomorrow's technology

### Gingerly there

It took more than a year of intense speculation and media hype to arrive. When it finally got here, it looked a lot like a slick scooter you strap on your feet. The scooter-like 'Segway Human Transporter', a revolutionary, self-balancing personal transportation device using an electric engine to propel passengers at 12 miles per hour, was recently unveiled by an 'inventorpreneur'.

The inventor, Kamen,

who's called this device Ginger after the actress Ginger Rogers (he had named it Fred earlier), has used a technology called 'Dynamic Stabilisation' that's designed to simulate the way the human body moves. Dynamic Stabilisation is achieved by using gyroscopes and tilt sensors



that monitor the rider's centre of gravity 100 times per second.

Ginger is driven by body movements; it moves when you lean forward and backs up when you lean back. The device is about the same size as the average human body and can go anywhere where a man can walk.

Kamen, the chairman and chief executive officer of Segway LLC, says they plan to sell Ginger starting late 2002. The company will manufacture

three initial models of the device—the i, e and p-series. The i-series will be designed for range and speed across different terrains, the e-series will focus on business applications and will haul up to 75 pounds beyond the rider's body weight, and the p-series will target the densely populated areas.

The potential this device wields is enormous, for the ordinary masses as well as the disabled, but cost and mass manufacturing remain major hurdles. Ginger will retail at \$3,000 (approx. Rs 1,44,000).